

BACKGROUND GUIDE (UNSC)

Agenda: “Addressing Security Crises and Regional Instability in the Middle East while Promoting Reconstruction, Governance, and Peace Negotiations among Key Stakeholders.”

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Method Of Research

This self-paced guide aims to give delegate flexibility in their approach to research the following steps are meant to provide motivation and guidance about some possible strategies and minimum expectations for completing this research successfully:

This Study guide is meant to be relevant and practical.

- Before you begin to research, first run through the entire Background guide. Notice the articles and section titles to get an overall idea of what will be involved as you proceed.
- Strive to understand concepts and overall perspectives regarding the United Nations system and the charter.
- Set personal guidelines and benchmarks regarding how you want to schedule your speech and documentation.
- Study the research content and the learning the core matter objectives. At the beginning of each study, guide yourself to the main points. Read the Background guide twice to ensure maximum understanding and mental faculty.
- At the end of each research segments, take the imperative notes that are relatable to the study. Clarify any missed portions by recollecting them.
- After you complete all the research, prepare for the End-of research Document by taking time to review the main points of each researched articles.

Introduction To Committee

The United Nations Security Council is one of the six organs of the UN Charter. It was first established in 1946 after the Second World War to address the failings of a previous international organization, the League of Nations. Its first session was held on 17 January 1946 in London.

The Security Council is composed of fifteen UN member States, five of which are permanent members the other ten members of the Council are elected by the General Assembly to two-year non-renewable terms.

The UNSC acts whenever peace is threatened and attempts to maintain international peace and security. This council pertains to 4 main purposes. It functions to maintain international peace and security; to develop peaceful and diplomatic relations among nations, to cooperate in solving international problems, in promoting respect for human rights, and to be a center for harmonizing the actions of nations.

Statement Of The Problem

4.1 Geopolitical Position:

The Middle East is strategically located at the crossroads of Europe, Asia, and Africa, making it vital for global trade, energy, and politics.



It holds over half of the world's oil reserves and key waterways like the **Strait of Hormuz** and Suez Canal, crucial for international energy and trade routes. It is also the birthplace of major religions, amplifying its cultural and ideological significance. Its location makes it a focal point for major powers like the U.S., Russia, and China, each seeking influence to secure energy supplies, political alliances, and military presence.

4.2 . Security Crisis In Middle East:

The Middle East remains a center of global focus due to persistent instability and security crises:

1. Civil Wars:

- **Syria:** A decade-long civil war involving multiple factions, including the Assad regime (supported by Russia and Iran), opposition groups, Kurdish forces, and extremist groups like ISIS. International efforts for peace have largely failed.
- **Yemen:** A devastating conflict between the Iran-backed Houthi rebels and the Saudi-led coalition, compounded by humanitarian crises like famine and disease.

2.Proxy Wars:

- Regional powers like **Iran** and **Saudi Arabia** fund and arm opposing sides in conflicts across the region, turning local disputes into broader geopolitical struggles.
- Global powers, including the **U.S.** and **Russia**, pursue competing interests, further entrenching divides.

3. Rise of Extremist Groups:

- Groups like **ISIS** and **Al-Qaeda** have exploited power vacuums, launching terror campaigns locally and globally. Though ISIS has lost territorial control, its ideological influence persists.

4. Territorial Disputes and Sovereignty Issues:

- **Israel-Palestine Conflict:** Renewed violence and failed peace talks continue to destabilize the region.
- **Kurds:** Ethnic Kurdish groups in Iraq, Syria, and Turkey push for greater autonomy, facing resistance from governments.

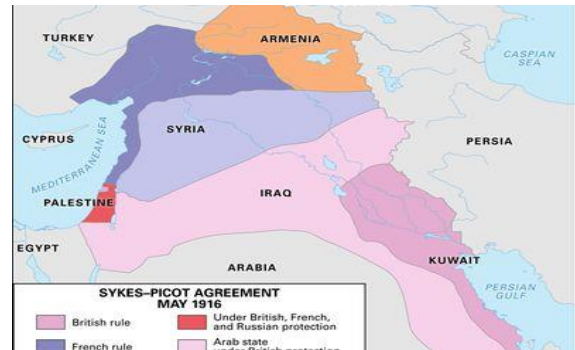
4.3 Governance and Reconstruction Challenges

- Post-conflict regions often lack functional governments capable of providing basic services. This perpetuates instability and invites extremist influences.
- Endemic corruption undermines trust in governments and international aid efforts, slowing reconstruction.
- Reconstruction programs often rely on international actors, sidelining local communities, which can create resentment and inefficiencies.
- Rebuilding infrastructure, stabilizing economies, and addressing humanitarian crises require significant resources and sustained global attention.

Historical Context

5.1 Colonial Legacy:

After World War I, European powers, particularly Britain and France, divided the Ottoman Empire through agreements like the Sykes-Picot Agreement (1916). These borders ignored ethnic, tribal, and religious divides, grouping conflicting groups within artificial nation-states. This laid the groundwork for disputes and grievances that persist to this day, as seen in tensions between Sunni and Shia groups or ethnic Kurds spread across multiple nations.



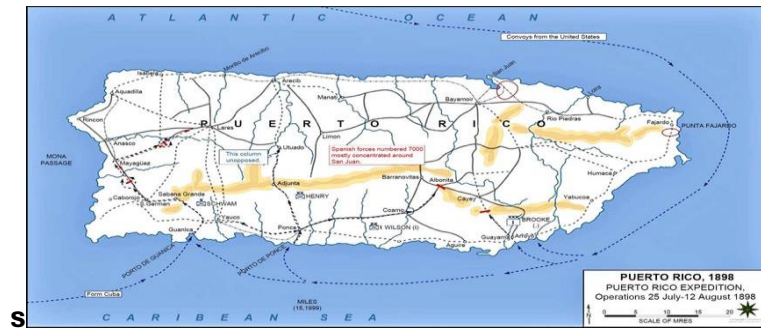
5.2 Arab-Israeli Conflict:



The establishment of Israel in 1948 led to multiple wars and enduring hostilities with neighboring Arab nations. Core issues include disputes over land, particularly the West Bank, Gaza Strip, and Jerusalem, as well as the plight of Palestinian refugees.

Despite various peace talks, the conflict remains unresolved, fueling wider regional instability.

5.3 Post-9/11 Intervention



The U.S.-led invasions of Afghanistan (2001) and Iraq (2003) aimed to combat terrorism and overthrow authoritarian regimes.

These interventions destabilized the region further, leading to power vacuums, the rise of extremist groups like ISIS, and prolonged violence.

The focus on military solutions often sidelined efforts for sustainable governance and reconstruction.

5.4 Arab Spring (2011):



A wave of anti-government protests swept through the Middle East, driven by demands for democracy, economic reforms, and social justice. While some governments were overthrown (e.g., Tunisia, Egypt), others descended into prolonged civil wars (e.g., Syria, Libya, Yemen).

The failure to achieve stable governance post-uprisings exposed deep-rooted institutional weaknesses, exacerbating instability.

PAST ACTIONS TAKEN BY UN

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) has actively intervened in Middle Eastern conflicts through resolutions, peacekeeping missions, and humanitarian aid. Despite its efforts, the complexities of the region and geopolitical dynamics have limited the effectiveness of these measures.

6.1 Major UNSC Resolutions

Resolution 2118 (2013) - Syrian Chemical Weapons:

- Adopted unanimously, this resolution aimed to dismantle Syria's chemical weapons program after evidence of their use in the civil war.
- The Organisation for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons (OPCW) supervised the destruction process.
- Challenges: Non-compliance by the Syrian government, continued allegations of chemical weapon use, and lack of enforcement mechanisms.

Resolution 2216 (2015) - Yemen:



Imposed an arms embargo on Houthi rebels and sanctioned key individuals undermining peace efforts. Called for a ceasefire and the return of Yemen's internationally recognized government.

- **Challenges:** The resolution did not address the humanitarian crisis, and the ongoing proxy war between Saudi Arabia and Iran complicated

implementation.

6.2 Peacekeeping Missions

UNIFIL (United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon):

- Established in 1978 to oversee the withdrawal of Israeli forces and restore peace in southern Lebanon.
- Its mandate expanded after the 2006 Israel-Hezbollah conflict to monitor the cessation of hostilities and support the Lebanese government.

- Challenges: Limited ability to prevent clashes and ongoing regional tensions affecting stability.

UNDOF (United Nations Disengagement Observer Force):

- Deployed in the Golan Heights to monitor the ceasefire between Israel and Syria.
- Challenges: The Syrian civil war and regional instability have hindered its operations.

6.3 Humanitarian Aid Coordination

OCHA (Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs):

- Plays a pivotal role in coordinating international humanitarian responses in conflict zones like Syria, Yemen, and Palestine.

WFP (World Food Programme):

- Provides food assistance to millions affected by conflicts, particularly in Yemen, which is on the brink of famine.
- Challenges: Access restrictions, funding shortages, and risks to aid workers.

CURRENT SITUATION

7.1 Active Conflicts in the Middle East (2025)

- **Syria:** A multi-faceted conflict involving the Assad regime, opposition forces, Kurdish factions, and remnants of ISIS. International players like Russia, the U.S., and Turkey are also deeply involved.
- **Yemen:** The Saudi-Iranian proxy war continues with devastating humanitarian impacts. Peace talks remain fragile.
- **Israel-Palestine:** Escalating tensions over settlements, sovereignty, and border conflicts.
- **Libya (Peripheral):** While not geographically Middle Eastern, the ongoing power struggle between factions backed by Turkey and Russia affects regional dynamics.
- **Iraq:** Instability persists with clashes between government forces, militias, and ISIS remnants.

7.2 Regional Alliances and Rivalries

- **Saudi Arabia vs. Iran:** This Sunni-Shia divide is the central fault line in Middle Eastern geopolitics. Saudi Arabia leads a Sunni bloc, including countries like the UAE and Bahrain, while Iran supports Shia factions like the Houthis in Yemen and Hezbollah in Lebanon. Proxy wars are fought in Syria, Yemen, and Iraq, fueled by this rivalry.
- **Turkey's Role:** Turkey seeks regional dominance and often aligns with Qatar, opposing Saudi Arabia and UAE in many issues. Its military interventions in Syria aim to counter Kurdish groups and establish influence.
- **Israel and Arab Nations:** Israel has normalized relations with some Arab nations through the Abraham Accords, such as the UAE and Bahrain, aiming to counter Iranian influence. However, tensions with Palestine and neighboring countries like Lebanon remain high.

7.3 Global Involvement

1. **United States:** Supports Israel, Saudi Arabia, and Gulf States to counter Iran and maintain access to energy supplies. U.S. interventions in Iraq, Syria, and Afghanistan have shaped regional dynamics.

2. **Russia:** Strongly backs the Assad regime in Syria to maintain its military base in Tartus and influence in the region. Aligns with Iran and opposes U.S. dominance.
3. **China:** Focuses on economic interests through its Belt and Road Initiative. While politically neutral, it maintains ties with Iran for energy security.

7.4 Humanitarian Impact of Ongoing Wars

1. Displacement and Refugees

- **Syria:** Over 13 million Syrians have been displaced internally and externally since the start of the civil war. Neighboring countries like Turkey, Lebanon, and Jordan host millions of refugees.
- **Yemen:** The war has displaced over 4 million people, with many living in dire conditions in camps.

2. Food Insecurity and Starvation

- **Yemen:** The UN has described Yemen as the world's worst humanitarian crisis, with nearly 16 million people at risk of famine.
- **Syria:** Food shortages and economic collapse have left millions dependent on international aid.

3. Medical Crises

- Bombings of hospitals and blockades have severely limited healthcare access. Yemen faces the spread of diseases like cholera, and Syria struggles with a lack of medical supplies.

4. Education and Livelihood Loss

- Prolonged wars have devastated schools and infrastructure, leaving millions of children without education.
- Job losses and economic stagnation exacerbate poverty, fueling cycles of violence.

5. Psychological Impact

- Trauma from violence and displacement has had severe mental health consequences, particularly for children. Generations are growing up with little hope for stability or peace.

PROPOSED SOLUTIONS

Short-Term Measures

Ceasefires and De-escalation: Broker immediate ceasefires in active conflict zones.

Humanitarian Aid: Strengthen aid delivery mechanisms to address urgent needs.

Medium-Term Measures

Inclusive Peace Talks: Involve all key stakeholders, including marginalized groups.

Reconstruction Programs: Prioritize infrastructure rebuilding and economic revitalization.

Long-Term Goals

Governance Reforms: Support anti-corruption measures and capacity building.

Regional Cooperation: Foster dialogue among Middle Eastern states to resolve disputes and build trust.

Questions a Resolution Must Answer (QARMAs)

How can the international community ensure adherence to ceasefires?

What role should regional organizations (e.g., Arab League) play in peace negotiations?

How can reconstruction efforts balance external support with local ownership?

What mechanisms can prevent proxy wars and external interference?

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